Foundations of Digital Marketing Assignment #1



Vs

CHRYSLER



Intro:

In today's modern and technocentric world, access to the multitude of online websites available on the world-wide web has simplified the methods in which people access information. Peoples ever increasing ability to gain access to knowledge and opinion through online resources has aided in gaining valuable insights and solutions to problems humans encounter in daily life. The internet or mobile web has allowed the common citizen to access websites that enable them to understand a plethora of complex information, done through the simplification of how this information is presented and communicated to the end user. Websites can successfully accomplish this goal when they contain an intuitive design, an easily accessible user interface and content relevant to what the user is searching. User interaction with a website can further improve when an online domain/website can perform complex algorithms in the online backend which can provide extremely valuable information for the user. This is particularly relevant when we analyze consumers with respect to their purchasing decisions. The process of seeking information online with respect to a brand's products and services can removes the barriers of monotony and tedium which forces users to dissect this information themselves by searching other offline sources.

For this reason, it has become vital for corporations to understand their consumer and post all pivotal information on their website so that a potential customer has all the information they need to make its purchase. Truly its own form of marketing. The following analysis will cover a comparison of two corporate websites, Chrysler (http://www.chrysler.com) and Ford automotive (http://www.ford.com). This paper will seek to determine whether these brands websites can successfully accomplish their marketing goal of providing valuable and insightful information to potential customers regarding their products and services and whether they can further enforce a purchasing decision on the consumer's end. This will be determined by analyzing which of the two brands possess a better website. The criteria being used to make this judgment are a website's design, ease of use, copywriting, on page optimizations, content and user interactivity. By judging these aspects of a corporate website, we will be able to essentially determine which one more effectively markets towards the end user with respect to a purchasing decision. Upon determining which website is considered better, our analysis will focus upon how each website can be further improved upon with respect to its user interactions.

1) Design

From a design standpoint, both corporations utilize a simple background with approximately two pages of content posted on its homepage. From an aesthetic standpoint though Chrysler does seem to have a more formal and modern webpage in terms of its presentation, it also lacks simplicity and consistency. Examples of this are with the font. On some section of the webpage the font will be extremely small and difficult to decipher while other sections on the page contain huge font which is inconsistent with the overall design. I also found that looking at the black background with the white font strained my eyes when looking at the page. Ford's design was more clean and clear, though I do sometimes feel as though there was too much empty white space. This did offer a clear look but also felt somewhat bright at times, especially on the vehicle showroom page. Ford also made the same mistake as Chrysler when it came to the footers at the end of the page (contact info, privacy policy) in that it was difficult to see. Chrysler retained the white font with black background while Ford has mostly grey font across a black background, which felt difficult to read.

On the other hand, Ford's website consists of a white background with dark font, which I found substantially more appealing for viewing. This is backed up by research as seen by the ____ study (refer to reference ____). Another critique of the design is regarding the social media icons at the bottom of both websites. Though it is satisfying to see both companies engaging with their customers through social media, I do wish Chrysler in particular put in more effort as to the aesthetics of those icons. On the Ford website, we witness a clean-cut design mimicking the look and colour scheme of how those social media brand logos are presented to the public. Meanwhile, Chrysler opts in for an uninspiring black and white colour scheme for all its social media click

throughs. This feels uninviting and generic, as none of these icons feel exciting to click on, nor is it easy to differentiate which icon clicks through to which social media website. Ford's clean, consistent and vibrant social media click through icons would benefit the company's social media presence as customers would feel inclined to click through to their social media page directly from the homepage. On the other hand, Chrysler's black and white colour scheme for its social media click through icons would probably drive down their potential CTR, as customers would not feel inclined to visit those pages due to these icons having an uninspired look. **1366×768 also remains as the most popular resolution amomg websites.**

Nevertheless, both website do retain a professional look and design decisions on both websites do not hamper the navigation. The images of cars are also pleasant to look at, and in terms of target demographic we can tell that both websites are appealing to different audiences (Ford with a rugged/family lifestyle look while Chrysler has more of an elite look and sophisticated appearance)

2) Ease of use:

Ease of use is an important factor when determining whether a corporate website can effectively communicate and convey without making it difficult for a customer to access its intended message. One way of determining the ease of use is the actual size of the content being downloaded. When analyzing both websites, Chrysler has 10.5 MB worth of content on its homepage vs 1.3 MB for Ford.com. Therefore, we can determine that the size of the content on the homepage for Chrysler is less accessible than that for Ford if a user has spotty data connection (Checked on http://smallseotools.com/website-page-size-checker/). I also tested the responsive design of the loading page on various devices. While I was north for the weekend I tested areas where data was spotty, I found that it was easier for the Ford webpage to load than the Chrysler webpage, though video content was slower to stream across both. Checking speed tests for both website online, Chrysler received a grade of E with a 2.80 s E load time versus Ford which received a performance grade of D (checked on https://tools.pingdom.com).

Another aspect of design that I found lacking on the Chrysler website was the absence of a search bar on the top right of the screen (the ideal spot a customer first looks to when deciding to a search a topic on any website). I feel as though neglecting the search bar would provide a poor customer experience for the customer who would have no method besides google to find what they were looking for on the website if they didn't know where to navigate. Chrysler does have a search bar at the bottom of the page, but the customer may not end up scrolling down the entire page to find it. Ford does not make the same mistake in that they provide a search bar right next to their ribbon on the homepage, simplifying any inquiry the customer would want to make on the website. Ford's inclusion of a search bar on the top right of the page may be beneficial; however, it is a missed opportunity that it is not made more apparent on the page (only a tiny logo is seen representing the search function). **Take screenshots.** Both websites do a decent job of being accessible for those with disabilities. However, the videos on the Chrysler homepage does have tiles that move automatically after a time, which may be too fast for someone with disability trying to read slowly. The fast-paced video may also be inconvenient for somebody with photosensitivity issues.

Both websites did a good job of providing all relevant links (contact us, privacy, product catalogue, nearest dealer, etc.) through their header or footer. However, I took issue that for the Ford website as I had to go to the Google page to get to their global website. It was much easier to do this on the Chrysler homepage where find your country was both on the top right and bottom of the page. From a marketing standpoint, you would never want to exclude foreign buyers from visiting that country's local website simply because they decided to visit Ford.com and then found it difficult to find their country's product catalog.

3) Copywriting:

If we were to judge both websites in terms of their copywriting, I would give Ford the edge when competing against Chrysler. Different taglines and keywords that Ford utilizes on its website are synonymous with the Ford brand and draw in customers through its witty undertones. An example of this is the term "**Go Further**" which is visible directly under the brand logo at the top left of the website's home page. In class, we already observed that most users visiting the page will concentrate on the first half of the page, with the majority with a interest of the top left. An apparent tagline is not noticeable on the Chrysler page which I feel hampers the experience somewhat as taglines help establish a brand presence in the customer's mind.

Ford also has cool taglines like **"Let us sweeten the deal"** for offers, **"We're pulling for American brands**" as a marketing message**, "Build and Price"** for estimates on various car models and "**What's happening at Ford"** to give customers a look at what Ford has in store for the future. In a way it seems as though there are trying to appease everyone, encapsulating multiple target markets. This was all made accessible from the home page. Chrysler has simpler taglines with text **("INCENTIVES & OFFERS, CHRYSLER SOCIAL"**) to highlight various aspects of their website and some text underneath that explains each one. It is not as clear cut as Ford and I wish more catchy text was used to garner my attention.

On the other hand, Chrysler does do a better job with their site map. It is made apparent that Ford just pasted all their Click Through pages in a cut and dry fashion with simple blue text and a hyperlink under a title section. As a user, I was almost feeling claustrophobic looking at this and felt as though it would be difficult to navigate and find the page I would want to visit. Chrysler on the other hand has portrait layout (instead of Ford's confusing landscape) a white background with black text (discussed earlier as more beneficial for a website). Clear titles also organize the page properly and make it easier for a user to discover the information they are looking for.

4) On-Page Optimizations:

4) Content:

In terms of content, both websites do a great job of creating a user experience which feels intuitive and helpful. Analyzing the homepage and other internal pages within the company website, both Ford and Chrysler do a good job of keeping the user engaged. One example of this is video content. Another feature which enhances the interactivity between user and the webpage is. Chrysler does a better job of interacting with the customer solely because it has some form of immediate engagement on every page. For example, on the home page immediately a video appears showing a family owning and enjoying their Chrysler with a spring clearance offer right next to it. I also liked how the video would eventually switch to another video relevant to the brand. Meanwhile with Ford there are more static images which act as click throughs and feel slightly less exciting than Chrysler does with its videos.

I liked both websites blogs as each company respected their own brand images and have a clean-cut design. I especially like how Chrysler included an option to subscribe to their email list right on the page. Also, many topics are immediately accessible. Ford's blog was a little bit harder to read, however both a good range of topics regarding their cars and brand, however I also liked that they incorporated twitter posts in their blogs along with tiles containing a ford image and profile pic of the member who posted.

What I enjoyed most on both websites was the ability to pick your car, the customize its feature. This seemed to be an extremely useful feature made accessible by digital technology. A customer can pick different aspects of the car (paint, model, type, etc.) and visually see how this would change the car, helping entice the correct purchase. Both websites did a good job here of representing the vehicle digitally through this form of customization but they also can establish a quote based on the features a customer has picked.

5) Interactivity:

Both websites go a great job of being interactive on their webpage. In the end, I would say Ford does a better job of engaging their audience with catchy slogans and is effective at communicating their product promotion through sleek images and clear and concise font, working as good calls to action. Chrysler lacks the same catchy slogans on their homepage, though they do express more straight forward text (Spring Clearance Sale!) and sophisticated branding creative to lure customers to a click through to their next page.

Chrysler, you can sign up for pdf brochures which you opt in to receive through email after registering your details while Ford has a media center website which was very well designed with a sleek blue background, nice tile images with branding, products and recent news, which did seem more interactive than signing up for the brochure.

Ford's contact us page is also laid out better than Chrysler's. Reason being is Ford has details posted throughout the page of methods to contact them (live chat at the bottom). Chrysler only has these details at the bottom and a search bar at the top, which is very confusing for a user who is only looking for contact details.

Though I would say on both websites the live chat should be much more apparent instead of all the way at the bottom. Overall, both companies do a good job.

Conclusion: Corporations can harness the power of the internet towards their marketing strategy by posting content relevant to their brand and sought out by potential customers. When a brand provides this content in a suitable and sophisticated manner online, customers increase their acumen regarding the offerings of a brand's lineup of products and services. This allows a user to have increased comfort and understanding regarding what a brand can offer, which may further reinforce a purchasing decision down the road. Product/service information offered online that is difficult to find or understand significantly decreases the likelihood of a customer making a purchase as they cannot assuredly make that decision without feeling satisfied that they are receiving exactly what they are looking for.